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From vision to action: Zimbabwe launches its National Public Health Institute

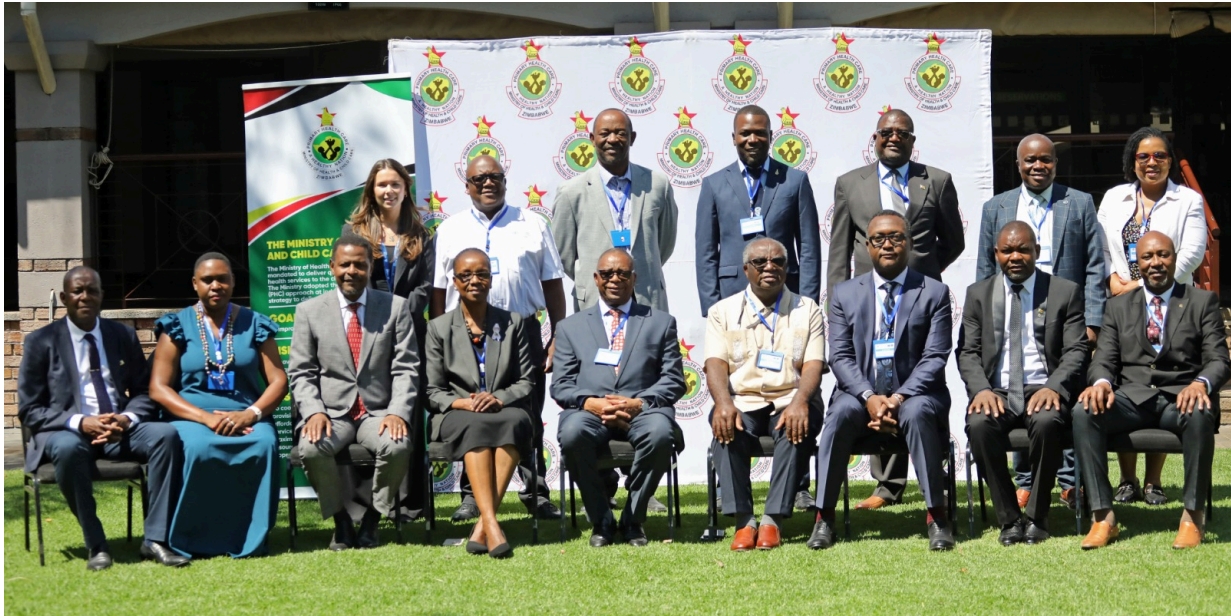
24 December 2025

Harare—Zimbabwe has taken a bold and historic step toward strengthening its health system with the creation of the **National Public Health Institute (NPHI)**, aligned with global best practice and the African Union (AU) New Public Health Order. This science-driven, semi-autonomous institution is designed to enhance the country's public health capacity and resilience. What began as an ambitious vision has now become a concrete reality, reflecting strong national leadership, regional collaboration, and global support.

A Strategic Investment in Health Security and Universal Health Coverage

National Public Health Institutes consolidate **Essential Public Health Functions (ePHFs)**, including disease surveillance, laboratory systems, emergency preparedness and response, research, and workforce development. By establishing the Public Health Institute of Zimbabwe (PHIZ), the country is strengthening its capacity to prevent, detect, and respond to public health threats, while advancing Primary Health Care (PHC) and Universal Health Coverage (UHC).

The journey started with the conceptualization of the PHIZ, led by the Government of Zimbabwe in partnership with the World Health Organization (WHO) and supported by catalytic funding from the **European Union** under the **Global Gateway Team Europe Initiative (TEI)**. Zimbabwe is one of ten African countries benefiting from this initiative, aimed at strengthening public health security. The vision was clear: to create a centralized hub capable of coordinating disease surveillance, emergency preparedness, research, workforce development, and evidence-based policymaking, while addressing both infectious and non-communicable diseases (NCDs).



From Vision to Launch

On 9 October 2025, Zimbabwe celebrated a historic milestone with the **official launch of the PHIZ**. Government officials, academic institutions, and international partners gathered to define a shared vision and roadmap for a resilient public health system. Hon. Dr. Douglas Mombeshora, Minister of Health and Child Care, announced that he would personally chair the PHIZ Steering Committee, signaling strong commitment to accountability, collaboration, and long-term health security.



Following the launch, **the Steering Committee was inaugurated on 12 December 2025**, marking the next phase in operationalizing the PHIZ. The inauguration was deliberately held on **Universal Health Coverage Day**, highlighting Zimbabwe's commitment to ensuring that all people have access to quality health services without financial hardship. The committee was tasked with providing strategic leadership, oversight, and policy direction, ensuring the Institute is built on strong governance, integrity, and professionalism.



Speaking at the event, the WHO Representative to Zimbabwe, **Dr. Desta Tiruneh**, emphasized the institute's critical role:

"A functional National Public Health Institute is not a luxury, it is a necessity for delivering Universal Health Coverage and safeguarding future generations." And added "PHIZ is more than an institution. It is a safeguard for the nation. It is a symbol of preparedness. It is an investment in the future of Zimbabwe."



The Minister of Health reaffirmed the Government's vision of a healthy, resilient, and productive population, emphasizing that a strong public health institute is foundational to achieving **Zimbabwe's Vision 2030** of becoming an upper-middle-income economy.



Learning from the Region

Shortly after the Steering Committee inauguration, a high-level delegation from Zimbabwe conducted a **learning visit to the Zambia National Public Health Institute (ZNPHI)** from 15 to 17 December 2025. The visit allowed Zimbabwean health officials to gain practical insights on governance structures, laboratory systems, operational models, and multi-sectoral coordination. This exchange underscored the value of regional collaboration, enabling Zimbabwe to adopt best practices and strengthen its public health infrastructure within a broader Southern African context.



PHIZ Today: A Centre for Public Health Excellence

The PHIZ now serves as Zimbabwe's nerve center for public health, consolidating functions previously scattered across different government units. It generates timely and reliable data, coordinates multi-sectoral actions, strengthens emergency preparedness, and promotes scientific excellence. By doing so, Zimbabwe is safeguarding its population from immediate health threats while laying **the foundation for long-term health security and Universal Health Coverage (UHC)**.

From conception to launch, through governance structuring and regional learning, the PHIZ embodies Zimbabwe's ambition, resilience, and readiness to lead in public health. With strong national leadership and committed partners including WHO, the European Union, and other stakeholders, PHIZ stands as a beacon of innovation, preparedness, and scientific excellence.

Its establishment is a commendable example of political commitment, technical leadership, and partnership-driven health system strengthening, charting a path toward a healthier, more secure future for all Zimbabweans. WHO calls upon other partners to

support the PHIZ and rally behind this transformative national vision and strategic reform in the health sector.

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